

[CHAPTER LEADERSHIP]

6 PAST PRESIDENTS AND A 20-YEAR EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR WEIGH IN ON BUILDING A BOARD

Real quick: Colton Mulligan, EO Nashville's incoming president, wanted to be intentional about his board. He sent ten past presidents six questions (six answered) and worked the slate with Sameera Lowe, the chapter's executive director of 20 years. The short version:

THE SEATS THAT CANNOT FLAKE [how many of the five who ranked seats named each]

Learning, 5 of 5. Membership, 4 of 5. The fifth picked Member Engagement instead, because "that's the scoreboard": renewals. **Finance, 3 of 5.** A light lift, but "you don't want to be the guy that lost track of forty grand." Governance, Forum and Social each got 2. Ask these chairs out loud not to flake on you.

HOW THEY BUILT IT [nobody led with a grand vision]

✓ DO

- ✓ Pick people over a vision, aimed at two or three priorities. "A year goes very fast."
- ✓ Lean on your ED's read on who is ready. One president said the ED did half the work.
- ✓ Recruit past the usual hands, including people never involved who would be good at it.
- ✓ Use the perks. A chapter-paid trip to GLC tips people toward yes.
- ✓ Put future presidents in Finance or Membership, where they see the whole chapter.
- ✓ Personally call everyone rolling off. Start renewals three months early.

✗ DON'T

- ✗ Seat the slackers you already know about, or people who do not play nice.
- ✗ Seat anyone who will not support you the way you need, or who is not all in.
- ✗ Trust the member who checks every committee box. They tend to commit to zero.
- ✗ Give anyone a third year in the same seat. "People just get tired."
- ✗ Count a yes as a commitment, or make asks before you and your ED agree who asks whom.
- ✗ Fill a seat nobody can define out of habit. Give it a real job or leave it off.

THE SOFT SEATS [where a flake costs the least]

Engagement, Mentorship, Special Projects, Community and "most of the last three rows" of the roster. Two warnings: Governance "is not important, until it is," and Member Engagement turns critical the moment someone owns renewals. Then run the foxhole test on the whole slate: who do you want beside you if something goes sideways in public?

"The only thing you will regret is placing someone on your board that is not all in on what you are trying to accomplish."

PAST PRESIDENT [REDACTED] THE OTHER THREE WHO ANSWERED HAD NO REGRETS AT ALL.

Sources: answers to Colton's six questions from six EO Nashville past presidents (Aug 26 to Oct 2, 2026; five in writing, one on a recorded call) and board-planning calls with Sameera Lowe. Names, to protect the innocent (or somewhat innocent), redacted. The long version, with quotes: [ForumPlaybook.com/board/full](https://forumplaybook.com/board/full)